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Shadrach, Meshach
and Abednego

Three young exiles who would not bow, and who found God with them in the fire.

Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah were young men of Judah taken to Babylon with Daniel, renamed Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego, and trained to serve King Nebuchadnezzar. Then the king set up a huge golden image and ordered everyone to bow. The three refused, with one of Scripture's bravest statements of faith: God is able to save us, "but if not," we still will not bow. Thrown into a blazing furnace, they walked in the fire with a fourth figure and came out without even the smell of fire.

At a glance

Hebrew names	Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah (Daniel 1:6)
Babylonian names	Shadrach, Meshach and Abed-nego; meanings uncertain (Daniel 1:7)
Family	Of Judah, among the young nobles (Daniel 1:3–6)
When	Taken c. 605 BC; the furnace is not dated
Key people	Daniel, Nebuchadnezzar, Ashpenaz, the accusing Chaldeans
Main passages	Daniel 1; 2:17–18, 49; 3
New Testament	Not named; compare Hebrews 11:34

"Our God whom we serve is able to deliver us ... But if not, be it known unto thee, O king, that we will not serve thy gods."

Daniel 3:17–18, KJV

The life of Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego

Dates are approximate (BC). Daniel 3 gives no date for the golden image. It is not certain how long after Daniel 2 it took place.

c. 605 BC As youths	● Taken and renamed
	Nebuchadnezzar takes young nobles from Jerusalem to train for his court. Hananiah, Mishael and Azariah are among them, along with their friend Daniel. The chief official gives them Babylonian names: Shadrach, Meshach and Abed-nego. <i>Daniel 1:1-7</i>
c. 605-602 BC Three years of training	● Faithful at the table
	With Daniel they ask for vegetables and water instead of the king's food. After ten days they look healthier than the others. At the end, the king finds them wiser than all his advisers. <i>Daniel 1:8-20</i>
c. 603 BC Nebuchadnezzar's 2nd year	● Praying for mercy
	When the king orders all wise men killed, Daniel asks his three friends to pray. God reveals the dream. At Daniel's request, the king sets them over the affairs of the province of Babylon. <i>Daniel 2:17-18, 49</i>
Date not given	● They will not bow
	Accused by certain Chaldeans, the three refuse to worship the golden image. They tell the king that God is able to save them, "but if not," they still will not serve his gods. <i>Daniel 3:1-18</i>
The same day	● Through the fire
	Bound and thrown into a furnace so hot it kills the soldiers, they walk free with a fourth figure. They come out unharmed, and the king praises their God and promotes them. <i>Daniel 3:19-30</i>

Key activities

Nebuchadnezzar says the fourth figure in the fire was "like the Son of God" (Daniel 3:25, KJV). The Aramaic can also be read "a son of the gods," and the king later calls him God's "angel" (Daniel 3:28). Many Christians have seen here an appearance of Christ before his birth. Others see an angel sent by God.

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- 1 Stayed faithful at the king's table.** With Daniel they asked to eat vegetables and drink water, and God blessed them with health and wisdom. *Daniel 1:11-17*
 - 2 Served well in Babylon.** They stood before the king, and later they managed the affairs of the province of Babylon. *Daniel 1:19-20; 2:49*
 - 3 Prayed in a crisis.** They sought mercy from the God of heaven when every wise man faced death. *Daniel 2:17-18*
 - 4 Refused to bow.** When the music played and the crowds fell down, they stayed on their feet. *Daniel 3:8-12*
 - 5 Answered the king calmly.** They said they did not need to defend themselves. God was able to deliver them, but even if he did not, they would not worship the image. *Daniel 3:16-18*
 - 6 Walked in the fire.** Bound and thrown into the furnace, they were seen walking loose with a fourth figure, unharmed. *Daniel 3:19-25*
 - 7 Came out unharmed.** Not a hair was singed, and "the smell of fire" had not passed on them. The king blessed their God. *Daniel 3:26-30*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links, not places that name the three friends.

Old Testament

Daniel 1:6-7, 11, 19	Named among the youths trained with Daniel
Daniel 2:17-18, 49	They pray with Daniel and are promoted
Daniel 3:1-30	The golden image and the furnace
Echo: Exodus 20:4-5	God's law forbids bowing to any image
Echo: Isaiah 43:2	"When thou walkest through the fire, thou shalt not be burned"

New Testament

Hebrews 11:34	Those who "quenched the violence of fire," often taken as them
Echo: Acts 5:29	"We ought to obey God rather than men"
Echo: 1 Peter 4:12	Do not be surprised at "the fiery trial"
Tradition	The Greek "Song of the Three," in the Apocrypha, not the Hebrew text

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What exactly did the three friends say to the king in Daniel 3:16-18?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think "but if not" matters so much? What does it show about their faith?
3. *Apply:* Where do you feel pressure to "bow" to something at work, at school or online? What would standing firm look like?
4. *Apply:* The three faced the fire together. Who could you stand beside this week when their faith is being tested?